Study 3: dated note before the first participant session

Date posted: November 5, 2026. This note is required by Section 4.6 of the Study 3 preregistration.

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Where the files are: this note is posted on the OSF project (https://osf.io/cnxdu). The code and other files listed at the end are posted in the project's GitHub repository (https://github.com/DGK-Law-and-Cognition-Lab/CharacterAI), which is archived on Zenodo. Their SHA-256 hashes are listed at the end of this note.

This note is posted before the first participant session. The TEST sessions led to no change to any prompt, script, participant-facing text, code or analysis, so a dated note is posted rather than an amendment. It reports two departures from the registered procedure (items 5 and 6).

1. IRB approval

- The amendment adding Study 3 (IRB-25-1121-AM-001) was approved by the UCLA IRB on **November 4, 2026**. The IRB application calls this study "Study 1b".
- Approved consent form: "Study1b_Consent_clean". The consent page shows it word for word, and its download link points to a copy on UCLA Box.
- Approved debrief: "Study1b_Debrief". Its text is the debrief page of the experiment.
- Copies of both are on GitHub, in study3/materials/.

2. Frozen code and deployment

Item	Value
experiment_version	study3-v1.0-2026-11-05
script_version	D1-2026-10-19
Git commit	b6dcab1ea9846a90082e7277753db028e7f1eb82, tagged study3-v1.0-2026-11-05
Pavlovia project	characters/study-2, projectId 518701. It is not the Study 2 project. A later commit (4441391) removed unused files from the repository root; the experiment files were not changed.
SONA study	experiment_id 3286
Counterbalancing Worker	https://study3-counterbalance.dgkamper.workers.dev, source SHA-256 de0be5a0d3984991c39eff75074a3f26bacf6f854e8d3d9e22997ddb14745893. /status showed next_slot 0 for 1d on November 5, 2026, and again on November 5, 2026 at 4:43 PM PST,

Item	Value
	before SONA was opened (next_slot 0, assigned 0).

Checks on the frozen build:

- static checks: all pass;
- Worker tests: all pass;
- end-to-end harness: 2,347 checks passed, 0 failed, across 17 runs;
- upload check: passes.

The experiment code (credentials replaced by REDACTED) and the Worker source are posted with this note.

3. TEST sessions

- **TEST01** was a full investigator session on the live deployment on November 5, 2026: LowA_LowE, bonding_first.
    - Its record saved to Pavlovia.
    - system_prompt_sha256_match and script_sha256_match were TRUE, and the logged hashes equal Appendices A and D.1.
    - The scripted openings S0 and S1 were word for word the registered texts.
    - All three closeness probes were logged, and all 18 model replies ended with finish_reason = stop, with 0 API errors.
    - Every field of the registered data contract was present.
    - After "Complete Study", the page redirected to SONA study 3286.
- **TEST02** was an investigator session on the live deployment on November 5, 2026: LowA_HighE, impression_first.
    - The tab was closed during the chat.
    - Its _PARTIAL record was saved to Pavlovia, slim partial, checkpoint_stage probe_1.
    - system_prompt_sha256_match and script_sha256_match were TRUE.
    - Between them, TEST01 and TEST02 ran both orders on the live deployment.
    - Both used the Worker's 1d_test counter (test slots 0 and 1); the 1d participant counter stayed at 0.
- **Automated TEST conversations:** 32 conversations with the live model were run on the frozen build on November 5, 2026, 8 per cell. Each used the cell's registered prompt and scripted openings, and the first message varied as Section 4.6 asks (an answer, a question, a greeting, a one-word reply).
    - Logged prompt hashes matched Appendix A in every conversation.
    - All 32 conversations completed: 352 model-generated replies, 0 API errors, finish_reason = stop.
    - Served model: meta-llama/llama-3.3-70b-instruct in every conversation. OpenRouter routed requests to SambaNova, AkashML, DeepInfra, Parasail and CoreWeave.

- Summary: TEST_live_model_conversations_2026-11-05_summary.json, posted with this note.

4. Length criterion and S1 check

- **Length criterion** (each cell's mean words per model-generated reply within ±10% of the grand mean): **met.** Grand mean 95.0 words over the 32 automated conversations, 88 replies per cell. No change to the length rule or the E blocks.

Cell	Mean words per reply	% from grand mean
HighA_HighE	100.4	+5.7%
HighA_LowE	97.8	+2.9%
LowA_HighE	92.4	−2.8%
LowA_LowE	89.5	−5.8%

The investigator session TEST01 (LowA_LowE) averaged 108.3 words per reply. It is not part of the criterion. M2 length equivalence is tested on participant sessions only (Section 4.6).

- **S1 check:** S1 reads as a plausible reply to an answer, a greeting and a one-word message in every cell. To a direct question ("Who are you, and why are you out here?") it answers only indirectly: S0 has already given Sylva's name and quest, and S1 mentions her search for clues about fire. No change was made. A first message that S1 may not fit is a sensitivity factor, not an exclusion (Section 9.2).

5. Departure from Section 4.6: how the TEST sessions were run

- Section 4.6 calls for at least 8 investigator TEST sessions per cell, run through the full participant procedure. Instead, the checks it lists were split as follows:
  - **Reply length by cell, the scripted turns, the prompt hashes, and S1 plausibility:** the 32 automated live-model conversations (8 per cell).
  - **The full page sequence, both orders, the three probes and their timer behavior, vignette 2, the _PARTIAL record of a closed tab, error logging and the credit redirect:** the end-to-end harness on the frozen build (17 runs, 2,347 checks).
  - **Live deployment (Pavlovia saving of complete and _PARTIAL records, the Worker test counter, both orders, the credit redirect):** the investigator sessions TEST01 and TEST02.
- No TEST data are analyzed, and no analysis changes.

6. Departure from Section 4.2: SONA disqualifier

- SONA study 3112, which served Studies 1 and 2, was removed from the SONA system when old studies were cleaned up. It therefore cannot be set as a disqualifier for SONA study 3286.
- Prior participants are excluded instead in two ways:

    - the consent eligibility statement says anyone who has already chatted with a character named Sylva cannot take part;
    - prior_sylva = "Yes" is exclusion criterion 9 (Section 9.2).
- No analysis changes.

7. Recruitment

- **Recruitment window:** from the opening of SONA study 3286 on November 5, 2026 to **December 3, 2026**, the end of Fall Quarter 2026 recruitment. The only extension is the one in Section 4.5: one further quarter if fewer than 200 participants are eligible at the end of the window.
- **SONA allocation:** 300 timeslot hours (60 minutes, 1 credit per session; about 300 sign-ups).
- **Stopping rule:** recruitment closes at 272 eligible sessions or 300 completed non-TEST sessions, whichever comes first, or at the end of the window (Section 4.5).

8. Monitoring and coding

- **Monitoring script:** monitor_study3.py, posted with this note. It reads only the fields listed in Section 4.5 and the Section 9.2 exclusion fields, and reports only:
    - counts by cell and order;
    - exclusion counts;
    - error and save rates;
    - probe completion counts;
    - contract violations;
    - the stopping-rule status.
- **Transcript safety screen** (Section 11.3): safety_screen_study3.py, posted with this note. It reads only participant-written text for self-harm keywords, and it lists flagged sessions without tabulating them by cell.
- **Coders:** David G. Kamper (PI) and Mira Patel (second coder). The second coder works only with de-identified transcripts and open-ended responses (Section 7.4).

Files posted with this note (GitHub, archived on Zenodo)

File	SHA-256
experiment_study3-v1.0-2026-11-05_REDACTED.js	888230d64ab6d1fa37945c7064bdcb15408cb3cf174385237adc2e0699cf3c86
TEST_live_model_conversations_2026-11-05_summary.json	bdadc15906b6365a514e1ad8c9a3c91564b3346880591915907cf98edbcda549
counterbalance_worker.js	de0be5a0d3984991c39eff75074a3f26bacf6f854e8d3d9e22997ddb14745893
monitor_study3.py	c692ad61c771786b85e211fce6db51595b51cfa1f80dbb7bef096978762f7dc9
safety_screen_study3.py	04d9e3edcda7286becbf391792bcabf132c1217f2f442622ecdedb5f40f98711

File	SHA-256
materials/Study1b_Consent-clean.pdf (approved consent form)	cfb2573b0692e6cedd192086a50dc3198bf0130ecff2c2d4d2626ed9bc6383fd
materials/Study1b_Debrief.pdf (approved debrief, rendered from the approved document)	ff26130ed06a431719bac9d5ac48c7f1f90e121c4c246a3ec12dc828acf1dd61